

Fig. 10.10: The Vaishali pillar in the vicinity of a brick stupa

Those who believe that Ashoka facilitated the meeting of a Buddhist council to give the final touches to sacred Buddhist texts argue that it was likely to have been held here. The *Mahavamsa* mentions this council, presided over by Moggaliputta Tissa. The pillared structure could well have been the religious assembly hall where the discussants gathered,[52] though there are no positive indications on the matter. At the same time it is worth remembering—and this feeling constantly recurs as one wades through the archaeology of sites showing Ashoka's patronage—no secular constructions such as palaces or sculptures that the emperor may have built have survived. If he had indeed invested substantial resources in such structures, it is unlikely that they would have all disappeared. His building ambitions evidently were an extension of his religious beliefs. It is thus likely that the Pataliputra pillared hall was made for religious use, even if the specifics of what transpired there remain unknown.